

► Warding off trouble

Perhaps used as a protective talisman, this 17th-century kabbalistic image features at its heart a Hebrew Menorah—seven-branched candelabrum—composed of words. The branches symbolize seven branches of universal knowledge.

Evolving practices

During the 1600s, a number of scholars began to make connections between branches of Kabbalah and emerging philosophical, scientific, or religious ideas. Abraham Cohen de Herrera tried to reconcile Kabbalah with philosophy, while Christian Knorr von Rosenroth's *Kabbala Denudata* provided Christian Kabbalists with translations of texts from Jewish Kabbalah.

The long-established distinction between meditative and “practical” Kabbalah (see p.87) persisted, the latter often still associated with magic. This was primarily due to its use of signs, symbols, and words—particularly those with links to the names of God or the angels—to interact with the divine and influence reality, rather than simply as a means to deeper understanding. Practical Kabbalists aimed to effect change through rituals and talismans, such as meditating on the meanings of the tree of life or inscribing the name of an angel on a metal disk.

Unlocking the universe

German Jesuit priest Athanasius Kircher is often called the last man of the Renaissance, due to his prolific academic pursuits. He was a revered scholar whose studies encompassed Egyptology, mathematics, medicine, astrology, numerology, and the deciphering of complex codes. Drawn to unlocking secrets, marvels, and great universal forces, Kircher undertook an investigation into understanding ancient Egypt's hieroglyphs, a popular endeavor of those interested in esoteric matters. His interests led him to make links

between Kabbalah and Egyptian mythology. His esoteric pursuits were important to the Hermetic branch of Kabbalah because of his belief in a universal knowledge that unified humans and their cosmos, and brought all fields of knowledge together. His version of the tree of life is still used in Western Kabbalah.

Moving on

Toward the end of the 17th century, there was decreasing interest in the Christian form of Kabbalah, most likely prompted by the corresponding rise of modern science. However, Kabbalah continued in various guises, including esoteric forms of Judaism and certain occult practices, while its influence also persisted within some branches of Hermeticism.



▼ Kabbala's Christ

This image taken from *Kabbala Denudata* (1677–1684) by Christian Knorr von Rosenroth—the Christian Kabbalist and Hermeticist—shows the head of “Adam Kadmon” or “The Great Countenance,” seen by many Kabbalists as a universal Christ figure.



“The world is bound with secret knots.”

ATHANASIUS KIRCHER, *MAGNETICUM NATURAE REGNUM*, 1667